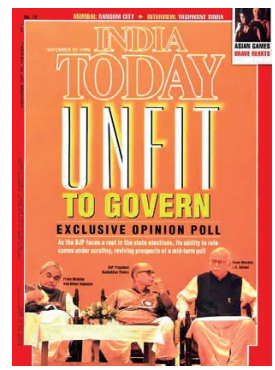
FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

It's the largest political party in the world. It has also been ruling the world's largest democracy for over a decade. That speaks of a rare measure of stability—the durable kind enjoyed by entities that have pretty much become the establishment. In the Modi epoch, the polity itself has readjusted to the entrenched presence of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) at the centre. So much so that BJP president J.P. Nadda had famously said in May that the party was now "capable" of running its own affairs, signalling it was no longer an underling of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS).

Yet after a subpar performance in the Lok Sabha polls this June, the BJP has not been as sure-footed as it was during Prime Minister Narendra Modi's first two terms. The withdrawal of lateral entry into the bureaucracy and the diversion of the Waqf (Amendment) Bill to a joint parliamentary committee highlight a small but growing collection of missteps, half-steps and steps taken backwards. The latest to join the list may be the caste census, a political hot potato that the saffron party had always resisted as a move that could "divide Hindu society". Intimations of a possible future softening now come with a qualified endorsement of such a step from the RSS, the BJP's ideological parent. Most of these are high-prestige themes on which the BJP has been deflected from a set path.



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After a chastening setback in the general election, the party is undergoing a churn at various levels. The immense growth the BJP has seen in recent times has led it to a paradox of success. The ideology of growth for growth's sake now haunts it. The import of defectors has increased local competition within the organisation; old hands who worked tirelessly for years find themselves sidelined while party bosses choose to please ideology-free political nomads who are in it only for power or to get their past sins absolved. Internal voices of dissent have been getting louder. Against this backdrop, new heads have been named for Bihar, Haryana and Rajasthan. Many other state units are beset with signs of turmoil. At the central level, the party has been unable to settle on a new president—Nadda has been given an extension till early 2025, seeing through a bunch of key assembly polls.

The uncertainty reflects a shift of the centre of gravity in ties with the RSS. The idea now is to go for a mutually acceptable face, indicating a remorseful compromise from the BJP. RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat's veiled critiques about "how true sevaks should never be arrogant" presaged a reversal of strength. At the end of its national conclave in Kerala on September 2, RSS spokesman Sunil Ambekar confirmed it in paternal tones, saying the "family matter" would be sorted out through "discussions". The Sangh is now unambiguously back as the moral guardian, and looks to be retaking the driver's seat. Witness the return to centre stage of RSS ideologue Ram Madhav. From being a powerful party general secretary with a roving beat across conflict states and "friends across ideological lines", he had been put out to pasture after falling out of favour with the BJP top brass in 2020. But in late August, he was named in charge of election for J&K, his old staging post. A perfect summation of how things have come full circle.

The RSS also sits in on other crucial decisions, including the choice of state unit chiefs. Senior Sangh hand Arun Kumar was spotted at Uttar Pradesh chief minister Yogi Adityanath's residence in Lucknow the other day, trying to sort out the leader's "issues" with his estranged deputy CMs Keshav Prasad Maurya and Brajesh Pathak. The sustained diplomacy has resulted in a truce of sorts, with Adityanath being allowed to lead the charge on the 10 assembly seats up for bypolls soon. As a top RSS leader put it, "*Mausam badal raha hai* (the weather is changing)."

In this week's cover story, Deputy Editor Anilesh S. Mahajan tracks this whole tricky process of structural readjustment. A critical phase of reinvention lies ahead, coinciding with four key assembly polls—Haryana and J&K first, followed by Jharkhand and the prized state of Maharashtra. Some amount of introspection has set in on its predatory aggression vis-à-vis other parties, the cause of heartburn within the rank and file, not to speak of questions around public acceptance. But BJP strategists have not entirely shed that path. In Jharkhand, JMM veteran Champai Soren has been brought in, while an old saffronite like Babulal Marandi has not yet been projected as the CM face. Meanwhile, Haryana CM Nayab Singh Saini is struggling in the long shadow of his erstwhile boss Manohar Lal Khattar, with all the attendant anti-incumbency baggage. In Maharashtra, the BJP faces its most difficult fight against a rampaging Maha Vikas Aghadi. The party is now focusing on welfare schemes to retrieve ground in both states.

It's difficult to predict how the reinvention will pan out. If the BJP manages to hold its own in the state polls, it will have bolstered its self-belief. The BJP is a resilient party. From just two seats in 1984, it clung on for 30 years till it got a majority on its own, repeated that feat in 2019, and is in power for a third term. Now to see whether the new changes bring its old mojo back.

(Aroon Purie)